

Wilderness Reflections

*The wisdom of the wise
And the experience of the ages,
May be preserved by quotation.*

— Isaac Disraeli

FIRST FIELD EDITION · 2026

Wilderness Reflections

First Field Edition · Source-Corrected Reading Edition

Editorial Note

This edition preserves the historic booklet's order and selection boundaries while restoring verified source wording where a reliable, reproducible witness is available.

Some selections are identified but not reproduced because publication permission or a sufficiently reliable reproducible text was unavailable. Their titles, attributions, scope, original positions, and index entries are retained, with a neutral omission notice in place of the selection text.

The historical transcription remains preserved separately. This reading edition corrects verified author identities and source wording without silently rewriting unresolved material.

*Prepared for Philmont Leadership Challenge faculty.
Oklahoma City · 2026*

Historical Introduction

The following introduction is preserved from the historic booklet.

This collection is for the Philmont staff; past, present, and future. It has been an ongoing project since 1985. Started by Susie Dobbs, Laura Lampe, and Ed Ohnemus and edited into 5 editions by Russ Riegel. This is an expansion of their work to be enjoyed by all scouts.

To staff of past summers, whether riding the tube or rail, walking in a stand of aspen or skyscrapers, I hope this brings life to your memories of summers in New Mexico. To you during this summer, I feel that many of these quotes will help in your teachings and relating to the beauty around you. And to those working in future summers, I feel that many of these quotes will help you in the understanding of what Philmont has meant to me and other staff members.

The quotations have been arranged placing favorites first in each section.

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Life

Source-Corrected Edition

Building the Bridge

Complete

Complete work.

An old man, going a lone highway,
Came, at the evening, cold and gray,
To a chasm, vast, and deep, and wide,
Through which was flowing a sullen tide.
The old man crossed in the twilight dim;
The sullen stream had no fears for him;
But he turned, when safe on the other side,
And built a bridge to span the tide.
"Old man," said a fellow pilgrim, near,
"You are wasting strength with building here;
Your journey will end with the ending day;
You never again will pass this way;
You've crossed the chasm, deep and wide,—
Why build you this bridge at the eventide?"

The builder lifted his old gray head:
"Good friend, in the path I have come," he said,
"There followeth after me to-day
A youth, whose feet must pass this way.
This chasm, that has been naught to me,
To that fair-haired youth may a pitfall be.
He, too, must cross in the twilight dim;
Good friend, I am building this bridge for him."

Will Allen Dromgoole

The Guy in the Glass

Complete

Text not included in this edition.

Dale Wimbrow

He Who Wisheth One Day to Fly

Excerpt

Excerpt from Thus Spake Zarathustra, Part III, "The Spirit of Gravity," section 2.

This however is my teaching: he who wisheth one day to fly, must first learn standing and walking and running and climbing and dancing:—one doth not fly into flying!

Friedrich Nietzsche

The Men That Don't Fit In

Complete

Complete work.

There's a race of men that don't fit in,
A race that can't stay still;
So they break the hearts of kith and kin,
And they roam the world at will.
They range the field and they rove the flood,
And they climb the mountain's crest;
Theirs is the curse of the gypsy blood,
And they don't know how to rest.

If they just went straight they might go far;
They are strong and brave and true;
But they're always tired of the things that are,
And they want the strange and new.
They say: "Could I find my proper groove,
What a deep mark I would make!"
So they chop and change, and each fresh move
Is only a fresh mistake.

And each forgets, as he strips and runs
With a brilliant, fitful pace,
It's the steady, quiet, plodding ones
Who win in the lifelong race.
And each forgets that his youth has fled,
Forgets that his prime is past,
Till he stands one day, with a hope that's dead,
In the glare of the truth at last.

He has failed, he has failed; he has missed his chance;
He has just done things by half.
Life's been a jolly good joke on him,
And now is the time to laugh.
Ha, ha! He is one of the Legion Lost;

He was never meant to win;
He's a rolling stone, and it's bred in the bone;
He's a man who won't fit in.

Robert W. Service

To Laugh Is to Risk Appearing the Fool

Abridged

Abridged circulating text; attribution unresolved.

To laugh is to risk appearing the fool.

To weep is to risk involvement

To expose feelings is to risk exposing ones true self.

To place your ideas, your dreams before the crowd is to risk loss.

To love is to risk not being loved in return.

To live is to risk dying.

To hope is to risk despair.

To try at all is to risk failure.

But to risk we must,

Because the greatest hazard in life, is to risk nothing.

The man, the woman, who risks nothing, does nothing, has nothing, is nothing.

Unknown

Believe in Yourself!

Complete

Complete work; authoritative source wording not yet established.

Believe in yourself! Believe you were made to do any task without calling for aid. Believe, without growing too scornfully proud that you, as the greatest and least are endowed. A mind to do thinking, two hands and two eyes are all the equipment God gives to the wise.

Believe in yourself! You're divinely designed and perfectly made for the work of mankind. This truth you must cling to through danger and pain; the heights man has reached you can also attain, believe to the very last hour, for it's true, that whatever you will you've been gifted to do.

Believe in yourself and step out unafraid. By misgivings and doubt be not easily swayed. You've the right to succeed; the precision of skill which betokens the great you can earn if you will! The wisdom of ages is yours if you'll read. But you've got to believe in yourself to succeed.

Edgar A. Guest

The Man in the Arena

Excerpt

Excerpt from "Citizenship in a Republic."

It is not the critic who counts; not the man who points out how the strong man stumbles, or where the doer of deeds could have done them better.

The credit belongs to the man who is actually in the arena, whose face is marred by dust and sweat and blood; who strives valiantly; who errs, who comes short again and again, because there is no effort without error and shortcoming; but who does actually strive to do the deeds; who knows the great enthusiasms, the great devotions; who spends himself in a worthy cause; who at the best knows in the end the triumph of high achievement, and who at the worst, if he fails, at least fails while daring greatly, so that his place shall never be with those cold and timid souls who neither know victory nor defeat.

Theodore Roosevelt

Come Into the Mountains, Dear Friend

Complete

Complete work; booklet wording retained.

Come into the mountains, dear friend
Leave society and take no one with you
But your true self
Get close to nature
Your everyday games will be insignificant
Notice the clouds spontaneously forming patterns
And try to do that with your life.

Susan Polis Schutz

I Expect to Pass This Way but Once

Complete

Complete circulating saying; attribution unresolved.

I expect to pass this way but once; any good therefore that I can do, or any kindness that I can show to any fellow creature, let me do it now. Let me not defer or neglect it, for I shall not pass this way again.

Unknown

I Will Act as if What I Do Makes a Difference

Complete

Complete circulating aphorism; attribution unresolved.

I will act as if what I do makes a difference.

Unknown

If You Don't Take Chances

Complete

Complete quotation.

If you don't take chances, you can't do anything in life.

Michael Spinks

At the End of the Open Road

Excerpt

One-line excerpt from "Lines Written Near San Francisco."

At the end of the open road we come to ourselves.

Louis Simpson

The More You Put In

Abridged

Abridged anecdote; booklet selection boundary retained.

The chaplain and his young son were camping just outside a small seaside town. Not far away was a tiny church that had no minister, so the chaplain offered his services for Sunday. No fee was payable.

As the chaplain and his son were passing out of the door after the service, the son noticed a small box which had on it the words, "For Contributions."

"Father, don't you think you should put something in the box?" the son asked.

"Certainly," the chaplain said. He dug into his pocket, pulled out a dollar, and placed it in the box. The two had gone a little way back to camp when a man came running after them.

"It's our custom to give the minister whatever is dropped into the box," he said when he caught up with them. "I found this dollar and here it is." And he handed back the money the chaplain had donated.

After the man had left, the boy look up at his dad. "Father," he said, "if you had only put more money into the box, you would have got so much more out."

Rev. Bill Sutherland

Grow Wild According to Thy Nature

Excerpt

Excerpt from Walden, "Baker Farm."

Grow wild according to thy nature, like these sedges and brakes, which will never become English hay. Let the thunder rumble; what if it threaten ruin to farmers' crops? that is not its errand to thee. Take shelter under the cloud, while they flee to carts and sheds. Let not to get a living be thy trade, but thy sport. Enjoy the land, but own it not.

Henry David Thoreau

The World Is Your Exercise Book

Excerpt

Excerpt from Illusions: The Adventures of a Reluctant Messiah; booklet wording retained.

The world is your exercise book, the pages on which you do your sums. It is not reality although you can express reality there if you wish. You are also free to write nonsense, or lies, or to tear the pages.

Richard Bach

Live as to Die Tomorrow

Complete

Complete circulating maxim; attribution unresolved.

Live as to die tomorrow. Learn as to live forever.

Unknown

Try Not to Become a Man of Success

Excerpt

One-sentence excerpt from a 1955 interview.

Try not to become a man of success, but rather try to become a man of value.

Albert Einstein

I Left the Woods

Excerpt

Excerpt from Walden, "Conclusion."

I left the woods for as good a reason as I went there. Perhaps it seemed to me that I had several more lives to live, and could not spare any more time for that one. It is remarkable how easily and insensibly we fall into a particular route, and make a beaten track for ourselves. I had not lived there a week before my feet wore a path from my door to the pond-side; and though it is five or six years since I trod it, it is still quite distinct.

It is true, I fear that others may have fallen into it, and so helped to keep it open. The surface of the earth is soft and impressible by the feet of men; and so with the paths which the mind travels. How worn and dusty, then, must be the highways of the world, how deep the ruts of tradition and conformity! I did not wish to take a cabin passage, but rather to go before the mast and on the deck of the world, for there I could best see the moonlight amid the mountains. I do not wish to go below now.

Henry David Thoreau

To My Friend

Complete

Complete poem; source placement unresolved and booklet wording retained.

You have such a positive outlook on life
Your words are always encouraging
Your face is lit up with excitement
Your actions are so straightforward
Your inner self helps you achieve so much
When people are around you they seem to absorb uplifting attitudes
When I think of you I can only think of happiness
and how lucky I am to know you.

Susan Polis Schutz

Don't Be Dismayed at Good-Byes

Excerpt

Short excerpt from Illusions: The Adventures of a Reluctant Messiah.

Don't be dismayed at good-byes. A farewell is necessary before you can meet again. And meeting again, after moments or lifetimes, is certain for those who are friends.

Richard Bach

An Agreeable Companion on a Journey

Complete

Complete maxim.

An agreeable companion on a journey is as good as a carriage.

Publilius Syrus

Happiness Is a Perfume

Complete

Complete anonymous maxim.

Happiness is a perfume that one cannot shed over another without a few drops falling on oneself.

Anonymous

The Real Way to Get Happiness

Excerpt

One-sentence excerpt from Baden-Powell's final message to Scouts.

The real way to get happiness is by giving out happiness to other people.

Robert Baden-Powell

No One Should Boast of Being Honest

Complete

Complete epigram from Waite Phillips's collection; original authorship undetermined.

No one should boast of being honest, dependable, courteous, and considerate for those are fundamental qualities essential to good character that everyone ought to develop and use.

Waite Phillips, compiler

Live Each Day as You Would Climb a Mountain

Complete

Complete booklet selection; attribution unresolved.

Live each day as you would climb a mountain. An occasional glance towards the summit puts the goal in mind. Many beautiful scenes can be observed from each new vantage point. Climb steadily, slowly, enjoy each passing moment, and the view from the summit will serve as a fitting climax to the journey.

Attribution unresolved; earlier print credits Harold V. Melchert

We Who Are Gathered Here

Complete

Complete quotation; original occasion not located.

We who are gathered here may represent a particular elite, not of money and power, but of concern for the earth for the earth's sake.

Ansel Adams

There Are Beginnings and There Are Endings

Complete

Complete farewell statement; original context not located.

There are beginnings and there are endings. What meaning and effect your experience here will have in your life only you will ultimately know. The responsibility as always, is yours to make of it what you will. Bon Voyage, my friends.

John Hurst

All Paths Lead Nowhere

Adapted

Adaptation of the path-with-heart dialogue in The Teachings of Don Juan.

All paths lead nowhere, so it is important to choose a path that has heart

Carlos Castaneda

The Road Not Taken

Complete

Complete work.

Two roads diverged in a yellow wood,
And sorry I could not travel both
And be one traveler, long I stood
And looked down one as far as I could
To where it bent in the undergrowth;

Then took the other, as just as fair,
And having perhaps the better claim,
Because it was grassy and wanted wear;
Though as for that the passing there
Had worn them really about the same,

And both that morning equally lay
In leaves no step had trodden black.
Oh, I kept the first for another day!
Yet knowing how way leads on to way,
I doubted if I should ever come back.

I shall be telling this with a sigh
Somewhere ages and ages hence:
Two roads diverged in a wood, and I—
I took the one less traveled by,

And that has made all the difference.

Robert Frost

Expose Yourself to the Possibility

Complete

Complete aphorism; attribution unresolved.

Expose yourself to the possibility of doing something remarkable.

Unknown

It's Kind of Fun to Do the Impossible

Complete

Complete interview quotation.

It's kind of fun to do the impossible.

Walt Disney

To Achieve the Impossible

Composite

Composite circulating aphorism; origin unresolved.

To achieve the impossible, one must think absurd; to look where everyone else has looked, but to see what no one else has seen.

Anonymous

To See a World in a Grain of Sand

Excerpt

Opening quatrain of "Auguries of Innocence."

To see a world in a grain of sand
And a heaven in a wild flower,
Hold infinity in the palm of your hand
And eternity in an hour.

William Blake

You Can Only Go Halfway into the Darkest Forest

Complete

Complete circulating proverb; cultural origin unresolved.

You can only go halfway into the darkest forest, then you are coming out the other side.

Unknown

The Worst Sin Towards Our Fellow Creatures

Excerpt

One-line excerpt from The Devil's Disciple, act 2.

The worst sin towards our fellow creatures is not to hate them, but to be indifferent to them: that's the essence of inhumanity.

George Bernard Shaw

Mending Wall

Complete

Complete work.

Something there is that doesn't love a wall,
That sends the frozen-ground-swell under it,
And spills the upper boulders in the sun;
And makes gaps even two can pass abreast.
The work of hunters is another thing:
I have come after them and made repair
Where they have left not one stone on a stone,
But they would have the rabbit out of hiding,
To please the yelping dogs. The gaps I mean.
No one has seen them made or heard them made,
But at spring mending-time we find them there.
I let my neighbour know beyond the hill;
And on a day we meet to walk the line
And set the wall between us once again.
We keep the wall between us as we go.
To each the boulders that have fallen to each.
And some are loaves and some so nearly balls
We have to use a spell to make them balance:
"Stay where you are until our backs are turned!"

We wear our fingers rough with handling them.
Oh, just another kind of out-door game,

One on a side. It comes to little more:
There where it is we do not need the wall:
He is all pine and I am apple orchard.
My apple trees will never get across
And eat the cones under his pines, I tell him.
He only says, "Good fences make good neighbours."
Spring is the mischief in me, and I wonder
If I could put a notion in his head:
"Why do they make good neighbours? Isn't it
Where there are cows? But here there are no cows.
Before I built a wall I'd ask to know
What I was walling in or walling out,
And to whom I was like to give offence.
Something there is that doesn't love a wall,
That wants it down." I could say "Elves" to him,
But it's not elves exactly, and I'd rather
He said it for himself. I see him there
Bringing a stone grasped firmly by the top
In each hand, like an old-stone savage armed.
He moves in darkness as it seems to me,
Not of woods only and the shade of trees.
He will not go behind his father's saying,
And he likes having thought of it so well
He says again, "Good fences make good neighbours."

Robert Frost

The Man Who Sat on the Ground

Excerpt

Text not included in this edition.

Luther Standing Bear

Then Here's a Hail to Each Flaring Dawn

Excerpt

Four-line excerpt from "A Rolling Stone."

Then here's a hail to each flaring dawn!
And here's a cheer to the night that's gone!
And may I go a-roaming on
Until the day I die!

Robert W. Service

What Is Life?

Abridged; Excerpt

Abridged excerpt from a speech by the fictional Infadoos in King Solomon's Mines.

What is life? It is the glow-worm that shines in the night-time and is black in the morning; it is the white breath of the oxen in winter; it is the little shadow that runs across the grass and loses itself at sunset.

H. Rider Haggard

A Human Being Should Be Able To

Adapted

Substantial adaptation of a Lazarus Long maxim; adaptation authorship unresolved.

A human being should be able to heal a wound, plan an expedition, order from a French menu, climb a mountain face, enjoy a ballet, balance accounts, roll a kayak, embolden a friend, tell a joke, laugh at himself, cooperate, act alone, sing a children's song, solve equations, throw a dog a stick, pitch manure, program a computer, cook a tasty meal, love heartily, fight efficiently, die gallantly. Specialization is for insects.

Adaptation author unresolved; underlying text by Robert A. Heinlein

As for Small Difficulties and Worryings

Composite; Excerpt

Composite text: an excerpt from Moby-Dick followed by an unidentified addition.

As for small difficulties and worryings, prospects of sudden disaster, peril of life and limb; all these, and death itself, seem to him only sly, good-natured hits, and jolly punches in the side bestowed by the unseen and unaccountable old joker.

—Herman Melville, Moby-Dick, chapter 49

There is nothing like the perils of the wilderness to breed this free and easy sort of genial, desperado philosophy.

Herman Melville for the first sentence; second sentence unattributed

When You Lose Your Name

Complete

Complete circulating saying; cultural origin unresolved.

When you lose your name, you become small. When you lose your spirit you become nothing.

Unknown

Play for More Than You Can Afford to Lose

Complete

Complete circulating maxim; attribution unresolved.

Play for more than you can afford to lose, and you will learn the game.

Unknown

If More of Us Valued Food and Cheer and Song

Excerpt

*One-sentence excerpt from *The Hobbit*, chapter 18.*

If more of us valued food and cheer and song above hoarded gold, it would be a merrier world.

J. R. R. Tolkien

Life Is Either a Daring Adventure or Nothing

Excerpt

*One-sentence excerpt from *Let Us Have Faith*.*

Life is either a daring adventure or nothing.

Helen Keller

He Says the Best Way Out Is Always Through

Excerpt

One-line excerpt from “A Servant to Servants.”

He says the best way out is always through.

Robert Frost

Once the Game Is Over

Complete

Complete modern rendering of a traditional Tuscan proverb.

Once the game is over, the king and the pawn go back into the same box.

Traditional Tuscan proverb

There Is Delight in the Hardy Life

Composite; Excerpt

Composite of four statements displayed at the Theodore Roosevelt Memorial.

There is delight in the hardy life of the open.

There are no words that can tell the hidden spirit of the wilderness, that can reveal its mystery, its melancholy and its charm.

The nation behaves well if it treats its natural resources as assets which it must turn over to the next generation increased and not impaired in value.

Conservation means development as much as it does protection.

Theodore Roosevelt

In This Age

Excerpt

One-sentence excerpt from "Essay on American Scenery."

In this age, when a meager utilitarianism seems ready to absorb every feeling and sentiment, and what is sometimes called improvement in its march makes us fear that the bright and tender flowers of the imagination shall all be crushed beneath its iron tramp, it would be well to cultivate the oasis that yet remains to us, and thus preserve the germs of a future and purer system.

Thomas Cole

Where We Begin and Where We Finish

Complete

Complete circulating maxim; attribution unresolved.

Where we begin and where we finish are little more than reference points. What truly matters is what happens between them.

Unknown

The Reeds Know What the Wind Does Not

Complete

Complete circulating maxim; attribution unresolved.

The reeds know what the wind does not: the power to endure harm outlives the power to inflict it.

Unknown

The Unknown Is Not to Be Avoided

Complete

Complete Philmont-circulated quotation; source and attribution unresolved.

The unknown is not to be avoided, it is to be examined, understood, and accepted. Fear should be handled the same way.

Unknown

We Must Learn to Reawaken

Excerpt

Three-sentence excerpt from Walden.

We must learn to reawaken and keep ourselves awake, not by mechanical aids, but by an infinite expectation of the dawn, which does not forsake us in our soundest sleep. I know of no more encouraging fact than the unquestionable ability of man to elevate his life by a conscious endeavor. To affect the quality of the day, that is the highest of arts.

Henry David Thoreau

When You Were Born

Complete

Complete circulating proverb; cultural origin unresolved.

When you were born, you cried and the world rejoiced; live your life so that when you die, the world cries and you rejoice.

Unknown

Most People Are About as Happy

Complete

Complete circulating maxim; attribution unresolved.

Most people are about as happy as they make up their minds to be.

Unknown

Hard Rain Cannot Fall All Day

Adapted

Modern adaptation of a thought from the Tao Te Ching, chapter 23.

Hard rain cannot fall all day, harsh winds cannot blow forever. If nature cannot make violent actions last, how can you?

Laozi (traditional attribution)

Keeping Things Whole

Complete

Text not included in this edition.

Mark Strand

Song of the Open Road

Excerpt

Opening seven-line excerpt from section 1.

Afoot and light-hearted I take to the open road,
Healthy, free, the world before me,
The long brown path before me leading wherever I choose.
Henceforth I ask not good-fortune, I myself am good-fortune,
Henceforth I whimper no more, postpone no more, need nothing,
Done with indoor complaints, libraries, querulous criticisms,
Strong and content I travel the open road.

Walt Whitman

The Fairest Thing We Can Experience

Abridged; Excerpt

Abridged excerpt in an unidentified English translation of “What I Believe.”

The fairest thing we can experience is the mysterious. It is the fundamental emotion at the cradle of true art and true science. He who knows it not is as good as dead, a snuffed out candle...

Albert Einstein

They Sleep Generally in the Open Air

Excerpt

Paragraph excerpt from The American Bisons, Living and Extinct.

They sleep generally in the open air, in winter as well as in summer, subjected to every inclemency of the weather. As may well be imagined, a buffalo hunter, at the end of the season, is by no means prepossessing in his appearance, being, in addition to his filthy aspect, a paradise for hordes of nameless parasites. They are yet a rollicking set, and occasionally include men of intelligence, who formerly possessed an ordinary degree of refinement.

Joel Asaph Allen

Always in Big Woods

Abridged; Excerpt

Text not included in this edition.

Wendell Berry

Every Man Dies

Excerpt

One line of dialogue from Braveheart.

Every man dies, not every man really lives.

Randall Wallace

Their Feet That Danced the Dance of Life

Excerpt

Three-line excerpt from Gilgamesh: A Verse Narrative.

their feet
that danced the dance of life
Which hovers close to death.

Herbert Mason

Those Who Have the Humility of a Child

Complete

Complete sentence from Kinship with All Life.

Those who have the humility of a child may find again the key to reverence for, and kinship with, all of life.

J. Allen Boone

Never a Day Passes

Complete

Complete quotation; original occasion unidentified.

Never a day passes but that I do myself the honor to commune with some of nature's varied forms.

George Washington Carver

At the Gates of the Forest

Excerpt; Fragment

Excerpt from "Nature," ending partway through its second sentence.

At the gates of the forest, the surprised man of the world is forced to leave his city estimates of great and small, wise and foolish. The knapsack of custom falls off his back...

Ralph Waldo Emerson

A Sabbath Poem

Complete

Text not included in this edition.

M. J. "Slim" Hooey (as circulated)

I Think I Could Turn and Live with the Animals

Excerpt

Opening line of section 32 of "Song of Myself."

I think I could turn and live with the animals, they are so placid and self-contain'd.

Walt Whitman

Cowards Die Many Times Before Their Deaths

Excerpt

Two-line excerpt from Julius Caesar, act 2, scene 2.

Cowards die many times before their deaths;
The valiant never taste of death but once.

William Shakespeare

Love Your Life

Adapted; Excerpt

Adapted excerpt from a modern circulating speech; cultural attribution unresolved.

Love your life, perfect your life, beautify all things in life; glory in your strength and beauty. Rejoice in the fullness of your aliveness. Seek to make your life long and full of service to others, to your people. And prepare a noble Death Song for the day when you are about to cross the Great Divide.

Unknown

Acceptance Is the Art of Making the Obstacle the Path

Complete

Complete circulating quotation; original publication unidentified.

Acceptance is the art of making the obstacle the path. Therefore, embrace the enemy. This is the lesson of the river guide; face the danger, move toward it, that is where the current is the strongest, and it will carry you around the obstacle. Use it.

China Galland (as circulated)

The Preservationist Is Not an Elitist

Excerpt

Two-sentence excerpt from Mountains Without Handrails.

The preservationist is not an elitist who wants to exclude others, notwithstanding popular opinion to the contrary; he is a moralist who wants to convert them. He is concerned about what other people do in the parks not because he is unaware of the diversity of taste in the society, but because he views certain kinds of activity as calculated to undermine the attitudes he believes the park can, and should, encourage.

Joseph L. Sax

One Aspect of the Machine World

Excerpt

Text not included in this edition.

Henry Beston

Plants Are Superb Opportunists

Excerpt

Two-sentence excerpt from Plant and Planet.

They are superb opportunists, making the most of different combinations of water, air, soil, and climate. Their grip on the planet, their capacities for colonization, and their integration with the environment are due to an astounding diversification and variety.

Anthony Huxley

If—

Abridged; Excerpt

Abridged excerpt preserving the booklet's selected lines.

If you can keep your head when all about you
Are losing theirs and blaming it on you;
If you can trust yourself when all men doubt you,
But make allowance for their doubting too;
If you can wait and not be tired by waiting,
Or being lied about, don't deal in lies,
Or being hated don't give way to hating,
And yet don't look too good, nor talk too wise;
If you can think—and not make thoughts your aim,
If you can meet with Triumph and Disaster
And treat those two impostors just the same;
If you can bear to hear the truth you've spoken
Twisted by knaves to make a trap for fools,
Or watch the things you gave your life to, broken,
And stoop and build 'em up with worn-out tools;
If you can make one heap of all your winnings
And risk it on one turn of pitch-and-toss,
And lose, and start again at your beginnings
And never breathe a word about your loss;
If you can force your heart and nerve and sinew
To serve your turn long after they are gone,
And so hold on when there is nothing in you
Except the Will which says to them: 'Hold on!'
If you can talk with crowds and keep your virtue,
Or walk with Kings—nor lose the common touch,
If neither foes nor loving friends can hurt you,
If all men count with you, but none too much;
If you can fill the unforgiving minute
With sixty seconds' worth of distance run,
Yours is the Earth and everything that's in it,
And—which is more—you'll be a Man, my son!

Rudyard Kipling

One Final Paragraph of Advice

Excerpt

Text not included in this edition.

Edward Abbey (as circulated)

You May Not Ever Travel to Maine

Excerpt

Excerpt probably from "What Price the Furbish Lousewort?"

You may not ever travel to Maine to see the Furbish lousewort. But the weeds in any patch of natural vegetation issue the same challenge. We have survived, say the weeds, since the Cretaceous. Man is a mere novice in evolution compared with us. He hasn't yet learned the secret of the weeds: how to create fail-safe communities.

Eric Ashby

Up to a Point in a Man's Life

Abridged; Excerpt

Text not included in this edition.

Louis L'Amour

There Are No Idealists in the Plant World

Complete

Complete circulating passage; original publication unidentified.

There are no idealists in the plant world and no compassion. The rose and the morning glory know no mercy. Bindweed, the morning glory, will quickly choke its competitors to death, and the fence row rose will just as quietly crowd out any other plant that tried to share its root hold. Idealism and mercy are human terms and human concepts.

Hal Borland (as circulated)

Until One Is Committed

Adapted; Composite; Excerpt

Text not included in this edition.

William H. Murray

I Said Out Loud

Abridged; Excerpt

Text not included in this edition.

Jack Kerouac

Keep Your Face to the Sunshine

Complete

Complete maxim documented in an undated interview record.

Keep your face to the sunshine, and you cannot see the shadows.

Helen Keller

Lessons for Life from Geese

Adapted; Excerpt

Text not included in this edition.

Robert McNeish (probable underlying author)

There Is More to Life Than Increasing Its Speed

Complete

Complete circulating maxim; attribution unresolved.

There is more to life than increasing its speed.

Unknown

Experience Is Not What Happens to a Man

Excerpt

*Two-clause excerpt from the introduction to *Texts and Pretexts*.*

Experience is not what happens to a man; it is what a man does with what happens to him.

Aldous Huxley

Leadership

Source-Corrected Edition

A Great Leader Takes People

Complete

Complete circulating maxim; original occasion unidentified.

A leader takes people where they want to go. A great leader takes people where they do not want to go, but ought to be.

Rosalynn Carter (as circulated)

In What Direction We Are Moving

Excerpt

One-sentence excerpt from The Autocrat of the Breakfast-Table.

I find the great thing in this world is not so much where we stand, as in what direction we are moving.

Oliver Wendell Holmes Sr.

What Lies Within Us

Complete

Complete maxim from Meditations in Wall Street.

What lies behind us and what lies before us are tiny matters compared to what lies within us.

Henry Stanley Haskins

Four C's

Adapted; Composite

Composite adaptation assembled from Disney-related transmission; authorship unresolved.

Somehow, I can't believe there are many heights that can't be scaled by a man who knows the secret can be summarized in four C's. They are curiosity, confidence, courage, and consistency, and the greatest of these is confidence. When you believe a thing, believe it all the way. Have confidence in your ability to do it right. And work hard to do the best possible job.

Unknown

Every Right Implies a Responsibility

Composite; Excerpt

Composite collected epigram; the source-restored and unidentified components are separated.

I believe that every right implies a responsibility; every opportunity, an obligation; every possession, a duty.

John D. Rockefeller Jr.

The most effective sermon is expressed in deeds instead of words.

John D. Rockefeller Jr. (first component); unknown (second component); Waite Phillips (compiler)

No Person Is Entirely Bad

Complete

Complete collected epigram; original authorship unresolved.

No person is entirely bad or entirely good. Therefore, learn to forgive yourself for error the same as you should forgive others.

Unknown; collected by Waite Phillips

Perseverance and Stubbornness

Complete

Complete collected epigram; original authorship unresolved.

The words perseverance and stubbornness are not synonymous but it is distressing to observe that many people do not recognize the difference.

Unknown; collected by Waite Phillips

A Man Can Fail Many Times

Adapted

One-sentence maxim restored from the underlying Burroughs form.

A man can fail many times, but he isn't a failure until he begins to blame somebody else.

John Burroughs (underlying maxim); Waite Phillips (compiler and adapter)

Being Good Is Commendable

Complete

Complete collected epigram; original authorship unresolved.

Being good is commendable, but only when it is combined with doing good is it useful.

Unknown; collected by Waite Phillips

To Become Competent in Governing Others

Complete

Complete collected epigram; original authorship unresolved.

To become competent in governing others we must first learn to govern ourselves.

Unknown; collected by Waite Phillips

Ruined by Flattery

Complete

Complete collected epigram; original authorship unresolved.

The trouble with many of us is that we would rather be ruined by flattery and praise than saved by honest criticism.

Unknown; collected by Waite Phillips

Argue for Your Limitations

Excerpt

Complete Messiah's Handbook entry from Illusions.

Argue for your limitations,
and sure enough,
they're yours.

Richard Bach

Nothing Worthwhile Was Ever Accomplished

Complete

Complete collected epigram; original authorship unresolved.

Nothing worthwhile was ever accomplished without the will to start, the enthusiasm to continue, and regardless of temporary obstacles, the persistence to complete.

Unknown; collected by Waite Phillips

Let Me Tell You Something About the People, Phil

Excerpt

Two-sentence dialogue excerpt from Witch Hunt.

Let me tell you something about the people, Phil. You lock any ten of 'em in a room and they may not elect a leader; but, I guarantee, they'll pick someone to hate.

Joseph Dougherty

Luck Is Where Preparation Meets Opportunity

Complete

Complete circulating maxim; attribution unresolved.

Luck is where preparation meets opportunity.

Unknown

Guts Is That Determination

Complete

Complete circulating maxim; attribution unresolved.

Guts is that determination that will not be denied.

Unknown

Freedom Without Discipline

Complete

Complete circulating maxim; attribution unresolved.

Freedom without discipline is anarchy, and anarchy is slavery.

Unknown

Ecological Sanity and Social Justice

Excerpt

One-sentence excerpt from “Brazil’s Amazonian Alliance.”

Ecological sanity and social justice always go together.

José Lutzenberger

People Need a Model

Complete

Complete circulating statement; original occasion unidentified.

People need a model. If they can see a place become beautiful, they're inspired to act.

Marion Stoddart (as circulated)

The Quality of a Person's Life

Abridged; Excerpt

Abridged circulating statement; original occasion unidentified.

The quality of a person's life is in direct proportion to their commitment to excellence.

Vince Lombardi (as circulated)

A Journey of a Thousand Miles

Excerpt

Two-line excerpt from the Tao Te Ching, chapter 64.

A journey of a thousand miles
Begins beneath your feet.

Laozi (traditional attribution)

Everything Begins with Leadership

Complete

Complete anonymous leadership maxim.

Everything begins with leadership; you start a spiral up or down.

Unknown

Where There Is No Vision

Excerpt

First-clause excerpt from Proverbs 29:18, King James Version.

Where there is no vision, the people perish.

Biblical Book of Proverbs

Hold Yourself Responsible

Complete

Complete circulating passage; attribution unresolved.

Hold yourself responsible for a higher standard than anybody else expects of you. Never excuse yourself. Never pity yourself. Be a hard taskmaster to yourself and be lenient with everybody else.

Unknown

I Learned This, at Least, by My Experiment

Excerpt

Three-paragraph excerpt from the Conclusion of Walden.

I learned this, at least, by my experiment; that if one advances confidently in the direction of his dreams, and endeavors to live the life which he has imagined, he will meet with a success unexpected in common hours.

He will put some things behind, will pass an invisible boundary; new, universal, and more liberal laws will begin to establish themselves around and within him; or the old laws be expanded, and interpreted in his favor in a more liberal sense, and he will live with the license of a higher order of beings. In proportion as he simplifies his life, the laws of the universe will appear less complex, and solitude will not be solitude, nor poverty poverty, nor weakness weakness.

If you have built castles in the air, your work need not be lost; that is where they should be. Now put the foundations under them.

Henry David Thoreau

Knowledge and Wisdom

Source-Corrected Edition

The Greatest Wonder

Excerpt

One-sentence remark recorded during Emerson's 1871 Yosemite journey.

The greatest wonder is that we can see these trees and not wonder more.

Ralph Waldo Emerson

You Cannot Stay on the Summit Forever

Abridged; Excerpt

Text not included in this edition.

René Daumal

The Smaller We Come to Feel Ourselves

Excerpt

Two-sentence excerpt from "The Significance of Place."

The smaller we come to feel ourselves compared with the mountain, the nearer we come to participating in its greatness. I do not know why this is so.

Arne Næss

The Search for Truth

Excerpt

Concise excerpt from Lessing's statement on truth.

The search for truth is more precious than its possession.

Gotthold Ephraim Lessing

The End of All Our Exploring

Excerpt

Three-line excerpt from "Little Gidding," section V.

And the end of all our exploring
Will be to arrive where we started
And know the place for the first time.

T. S. Eliot

Once You Know Something

Complete

Complete aphorism; attribution unresolved.

Once you know something, you can no longer believe it.

Unknown

Learning Is Finding Out

Excerpt

Complete four-part Messiah's Handbook passage from Illusions.

Learning is finding out what you already know.

Doing is demonstrating that you know it.

Teaching is reminding others that they know it just as well as you.

You are all learners, doers, and teachers.

Richard Bach

An Awareness of the Totality of the Person

Complete

Complete booklet passage; source and attribution unresolved.

The thing that I think is most important at this moment is an awareness of the totality of the person. One of the greatest stumbling blocks that people have today is understanding that one cannot experience life from the neck up... If I could I would wave a magic wand and have them be automatically convinced that brain existence is only a small part of their lives. They are missing out on a whole fantastic world.

Unknown

A Little Learning

Complete

Complete circulating maxim; original occasion unidentified.

A little learning is not a dangerous thing for one who does not mistake it for a great deal.

William Allen White (as circulated)

The Best Informed People

Complete

Complete collected epigram; original authorship unresolved.

The best informed people are those with acute observation and who are inquisitive to be continually asking “Why?”

Unknown; collected by Waite Phillips

Patience Is the Companion of Wisdom

Excerpt

Opening-clause excerpt from On Patience, chapter 5.

Patience is the companion of wisdom.

Augustine of Hippo

Must We Always Teach Our Children with Books?

Complete

Complete circulating statement; original occasion unidentified.

Must we always teach our children with books? Let them look at the stars and the mountains above. Let them look at the waters and the trees and flowers on Earth. Then they will begin to think, and to think is the beginning of a real education.

B. David Polis

I Have a Low Opinion of Mountain Books

Abridged; Composite; Excerpt

Abridged composite excerpt from Muir's 1872 letter and journal version.

I have a low opinion of mountain books; they are but piles of stones set up to show where other minds have been, or at best signal smokes to call attention... One day's exposure to mountains is better than cartloads of books.

John Muir

For Afterwards a Man Finds Pleasure

Excerpt

One-sentence excerpt from The Odyssey, book 15.

For afterwards a man finds pleasure in his pains, when he has suffered long and wandered long, so I will tell you what you ask and seek to know.

Homer; translated by George Herbert Palmer

He Who Resolves Never to Ransack Any Mind

Excerpt

One-sentence excerpt from Reynolds's sixth Discourse.

He who resolves never to ransack any mind but his own, will be soon reduced, from mere barrenness, to the poorest of all imitations; he will be obliged to imitate himself, and to repeat what he has before often repeated.

Sir Joshua Reynolds

The Old Lakota Were Wise

Abridged; Excerpt

Abridged excerpt from Land of the Spotted Eagle.

The old Lakota were wise. They knew that man's heart, away from nature, becomes hard; they knew that lack of respect for growing, living things soon led to lack of respect for humans too.

Luther Standing Bear

Natural Wilderness Is a Factor for World Stability

Abridged; Composite; Excerpt

Abridged composite of two statements from the fourth Wilderness and Plenty lecture.

Natural wilderness is a factor for world stability, not some remote place inimical to the human being.

It is not remote or indifferent, but an active agent in maintaining a habitable world.

Sir Frank Fraser Darling

Remember What You Have Seen

Excerpt

Four-line circulating verse; claimed cultural origin unresolved.

Then he was told:
Remember what you have seen,
Because everything forgotten
Returns to the circling winds.

Unknown

Many of Our Greatest American Thinkers

Excerpt

Complete sentence from “The Forest for Recreation.”

Many of our greatest American thinkers—men of the caliber of Thomas Jefferson, Henry Thoreau, Mark Twain, William James, and John Muir—have found the forest an effective stimulus to original thought.

Robert Marshall

Come Forth into the Light of Things

Excerpt

Two-line excerpt from “The Tables Turned.”

Come forth into the light of things,
Let Nature be your teacher.

William Wordsworth

Society Speaks and All Men Listen

Complete

Complete modern maxim; attribution unresolved.

Society speaks and all men listen; mountains speak and wise men listen.

Unknown

Observe All of the Light

Adapted; Excerpt

Loose modern adaptation of a thought from the Tao Te Ching, chapter 28.

Observe all of the light that surrounds you; but, you remember the dark that is there.

Laozi (traditional attribution)

I Only Went Out for a Walk

Excerpt

Complete journal sentence, commonly dated 1913.

I only went out for a walk, and finally concluded to stay out till sundown; for going out, I found, was really going in.

John Muir

To Allow Mystery

Abridged; Excerpt

Abridged excerpt from Of Wolves and Men.

To allow mystery, which is to say to yourself, there could be more, there could be things we don't understand, is not to damn knowledge.

Barry Lopez

Life Is Change

Complete

Complete modern maxim; original provenance unresolved.

Life is change; growth is optional; choose wisely.

Karen Kaiser Clark (as circulated)

The Secret of the Making of the Best Persons

Excerpt

Two-line excerpt from "Song of the Open Road," section 6.

Now I see the secret of the making of the best persons,
It is to grow in the open air and to eat and sleep with the earth.

Walt Whitman

Those Who Know Do Not Talk

Excerpt

Opening two-line excerpt from the Tao Te Ching, chapter 56.

Those who know do not talk.

Those who talk do not know.

Laozi (traditional attribution)

The Fact Remains

Complete

Complete booklet passage; source and attribution unresolved.

The fact remains that the people who profess to know about these things and to love them haven't the vaguest notion of how to see nature. They don't know where to find it, they don't know how to experience it, and if they demonstrate the existence of it they do so on a field trip which is more a social outing than a field trip. If anything, they do more damage to nature by their activity than they do if they never brought the kids out at all. The point is that people should find these things out for themselves. You shouldn't have to go to some expert to know that if you look here or there you'll find something. You're there - look! It's as simple as that.

Unknown

Born with Curiosity and Wonder

Excerpt

Complete passage from Reflections from the North Country.

While we are born with curiosity and wonder and our early years full of the adventure they bring, I know such inherent joys are often lost. I also know that, being deep within us, their latent glow can be fanned to flame again by awareness and an open mind.

Sigurd F. Olson

Awaken People's Curiosity

Complete

Complete circulating passage; original provenance unresolved.

Do not try to satisfy your vanity by teaching a great many things. Awaken people's curiosity. It is enough to open minds; do not overload them. Put there just a spark. If there is some good inflammable stuff, it will catch fire.

Anatole France (as circulated)

If We Are to Have Broad-Thinking Men and Women

Excerpt

One-sentence professional statement associated with Carhart's early Forest Service work.

If we are to have broad-thinking men and women of high mentality, of good physique and with a true perspective on life, we must allow our populace a communion with nature in areas of more or less wilderness conditions.

Arthur H. Carhart

Or Speak to the Earth

Excerpt

First-clause excerpt from Job 12:8, King James Version.

Or speak to the earth, and it shall teach thee.

Biblical Book of Job

If You Plan for a Year

Adapted; Excerpt

Modern adaptation of a passage in the Guanzi.

If you plan for a year, plant rice. If you plan for ten years, plant trees. If you plan for 100 years, educate your children.

Unknown modern adapter; derived from the Guanzi

The Forests and This Planet Are Alive

Complete

Complete circulating statement; original occasion unidentified.

I am trying to save the knowledge that the forests and this planet are alive, to give it back to you who have lost the understanding.

Paulinho Paiakan (as circulated)

Of What Avail Is an Open Eye

Complete

Complete aphorism; attribution unresolved.

Of what avail is an open eye, if the heart is blind?

Unknown

I Have Learned a Lot from Trees

Abridged; Excerpt

Closing portion of a longer oral statement published in Touch the Earth.

I have learned a lot from trees; sometimes about the weather, sometimes about the animals, sometimes about the Great Spirit.

Tatanga Mani (Walking Buffalo)

If You Understand

Complete

Complete modern saying; traditional provenance unresolved.

If you understand, things are just as they are; if you do not understand, things are just as they are.

Anonymous

Believe One Who Knows

Excerpt

Excerpt from Letter 106 to Henry Murdach.

Believe one who knows: you will find something greater in woods than in books. Trees and stones will teach you that which you can never learn from masters.

Bernard of Clairvaux

I Wonder If the Mountains Still Stand

Complete

Complete anonymous mountain epigram.

I wonder if the mountains still stand when I turn my head, or do they dip their peaks and nod at my retreating back.

Anonymous

All Things Excellent

Excerpt

Final sentence of Ethics, part V, proposition 42, scholium.

But all things excellent are as difficult as they are rare.

Baruch Spinoza

When I Go Quiet

Excerpt

Reported statement in William Least Heat-Moon's Blue Highways.

When I go quiet I stop hearing myself and start hearing the world outside me. Then I hear something very great.

Brother Patrick Duffy, as recorded by William Least Heat-Moon

The World Is a Looking Glass

Abridged; Excerpt

Excerpt from Vanity Fair, chapter 2.

The world is a looking glass, and gives back to every man the reflection of his own face. Frown at it, and it will in turn look sourly upon you; laugh at it and with it, and it is a jolly kind companion.

William Makepeace Thackeray

In the Midst of Winter

Excerpt

Final sentence of "Return to Tipasa"; booklet translation retained.

In the midst of winter I finally learned that there was in me an invincible summer.

Albert Camus

A Ruin Is Not Just Something

Complete

Complete circulating statement; original provenance unresolved.

A ruin is not just something that happened long ago to someone else; its history is that of us all, the transience of power, of ideas, of all human endeavors.

George B. Schaller (as circulated)

Perspective - Use It or Lose It

Excerpt

Text not included in this edition.

Richard Bach

The Simplest Questions

Excerpt

Messiah's Handbook passage from Illusions.

The simplest questions are the most profound. Where were you born? Where is your home? Where are you going? What are you doing? Think about these once in a while, and watch your answers change.

Richard Bach

The Old People Came Literally to Love the Soil

Excerpt

Text not included in this edition.

Luther Standing Bear

The White Man Does Not Understand the Indian

Excerpt

Text not included in this edition.

Luther Standing Bear

We Have Loved the Stars Too Fondly

Adapted; Excerpt

Epitaph for John and Phoebe Brashear, adapted from Sarah Williams.

We have loved the stars too fondly to be fearful of the night.

Sarah Williams; adapted for John and Phoebe Brashear

The World Is Round

Complete

Complete statement, cited to Parade in 1958.

The world is round and the place which may seem like the end may also be only the beginning.

Ivy Baker Priest

He That Riseth Late

Excerpt

First clause of an August 1742 Poor Richard's Almanack maxim.

He that riseth late, must trot all day.

Benjamin Franklin

Pilgrimage to the Place of the Wise

Complete

Complete saying; Sufi provenance unresolved.

Pilgrimage to the place of the wise is to escape the flame of separation from nature.

Anonymous

You Are Never Given a Wish

Excerpt

Messiah's Handbook passage from Illusions.

You are never given a wish without also being given the power to make it true. You may have to work for it, however.

Richard Bach

The Indian & the Cricket

Adapted; Complete

Text not included in this edition.

Dave Moriah (adapter); original author unknown

In the Point of Rest

Excerpt

Text not included in this edition.

Dag Hammarskjöld

The Mental Domain of Phantasy

Abridged; Excerpt

Abridged excerpt from lecture 23, "The Paths to the Formation of Symptoms."

The creation of the mental domain of phantasy has a complete counterpart in the establishment of "reservations" and "nature-parks" in places where the inroads of agriculture, traffic, or industry threaten to change the original face of the earth rapidly into something unrecognizable. . . .

The "reservation" is to maintain the old condition of things which has been regretfully sacrificed to necessity everywhere else; there everything may grow and spread as it pleases, including what is useless and even what is harmful. The mental realm of phantasy is also such a reservation reclaimed from the encroachments of the reality-principle.

Sigmund Freud

To Know One's Landscape

Complete

Complete circulating passage; original provenance unresolved.

To know one's landscape, to feel in sympathy with it, is often to be at peace with life. When all the world seems wrong and the burdens overwhelming he can look out on the familiar fields and hills or get among them and give way to their beauties of form and color as a resource within himself that will be an ever-present power of recuperation.

Richard E. Dodge (as circulated)

Two Somewhat Different Epigrams

Excerpt

Text not included in this edition.

Langston Hughes

Discovery Consists of Looking

Adapted; Complete

Complete circulating paraphrase; original provenance unresolved.

Discovery consists of looking at the same thing as everyone else and thinking something different.

Albert Szent-Györgyi (as circulated)

It Is the Love of Country

Excerpt

Two sentences from remarks to the 1908 White House Conference on Conservation.

It is the love of country that has lighted and that keeps glowing the holy fire of patriotism. And this love is excited, primarily, by the beauty of the country.

J. Horace McFarland

Rain and the Rhinoceros

Abridged; Excerpt

Text not included in this edition.

Thomas Merton

Everywhere Is Walking Distance

Complete

Complete one-liner; wording retained from the booklet.

Everywhere is walking distance, if you have the time.

Steven Wright (as circulated)

You Can't Be Lost

Complete

Complete anonymous saying.

You can't be lost if you don't care where you are.

Anonymous

There Isn't Enough Darkness

Adapted; Complete

Complete modern variant of an older maxim.

There isn't enough darkness in all the world to snuff out the light of one little candle.

Anonymous

I Think Over My Small Adventures

Abridged; Adapted; Excerpt

Text not included in this edition.

Anonymous Inuit singer

A Human Being Is Part of the Whole

Excerpt

Text not included in this edition.

Albert Einstein

You Ask Me to Plow the Ground

Abridged; Excerpt

Nearly complete recorded statement published by James Mooney in 1896.

You ask me to plow the ground. Shall I take a knife and tear my mother's bosom? Then when I die she will not take me to her bosom to rest. You ask me to dig for stone. Shall I dig under her skin for her bones? Then when I die I cannot enter her body to be born again. You ask me to cut grass and make hay and sell it and be rich like white men. But how dare I cut off my mother's hair?

Smohalla

Hope and the Future

Excerpt

Complete sentence from "Walking."

Hope and the future for me are not in lawns and cultivated fields, not in towns and cities, but in the impervious and quaking swamps.

Henry David Thoreau

If It Were Required to Know

Excerpt

Journal passage from October 1859.

If it were required to know the position of the fruit-dots or the character of the indusium, nothing could be easier to ascertain; but if it is required that you be affected by ferns, that they amount to anything, signify anything to you, that they be another sacred scripture and revelation to you, helping to redeem your life, this end is not so easily accomplished.

Henry David Thoreau

We Are Affected Like the Earth

Abridged; Excerpt

Passage from the journal entry for March 21, 1853.

We are affected like the earth, and yield to the elemental tenderness. The frost is coming out of me, and I am heaved like the road. Winter breaks up within us; accumulated masses of ice and snow dissolve, and thoughts like a freshet pour down unwonted channels.

Henry David Thoreau

He Who Has Known How to Love the Land

Complete

Complete circulating statement; original provenance unresolved.

He who has known how to love the land has loved eternity.

Stefan Žeromski (as circulated)

All That Glisters; Not All Those Who Wander

Composite; Excerpt

*Composite of lines from *The Merchant of Venice* and "The Riddle of Strider."*

All that glisters is not gold.

William Shakespeare

Not all those who wander are lost.

William Shakespeare and J. R. R. Tolkien

I Went to the Woods

Excerpt

Extended passage from Walden, chapter 2.

I went to the woods because I wished to live deliberately, to front only the essential facts of life, and see if I could not learn what it had to teach, and not, when I came to die, discover that I had not lived. I did not wish to live what was not life, living is so dear; nor did I wish to practise resignation, unless it was quite necessary. I wanted to live deep and suck out all the marrow of life, to live so sturdily and Spartan-like as to put to rout all that was not life, to cut a broad swath and shave close, to drive life into a corner, and reduce it to its lowest terms, and, if it proved to be mean, why then to get the whole and genuine meanness of it, and publish its meanness to the world; or if it were sublime, to know it by experience, and be able to give a true account of it in my next excursion. For most men, it appears to me, are in a strange uncertainty about it, whether it is of the devil or of God, and have somewhat hastily concluded that it is the chief end of man here to “glorify God and enjoy him forever.”

Henry David Thoreau

No Matter How Cold and Wet You Are

Excerpt

Woodsmen's advice recalled by Sigurd F. Olson in Open Horizons.

No matter how cold and wet you are, you're always warm and dry.

Anonymous woodsman, as reported by Sigurd F. Olson

A Californian Whom I Had Recently the Pleasure of Meeting

Excerpt

Passage from "The Genteel Tradition in American Philosophy."

A Californian whom I had recently the pleasure of meeting observed that if the philosophers had lived among your mountains, their systems would have been different from what they are. Certainly, I should say, very different from what those systems are which the European genteel tradition has handed down since Socrates; for these systems are egotistical; directly or indirectly they are anthropocentric, and inspired by the conceited notion that man, or human reason, or the human distinction between good and evil, is the centre and pivot of the universe. That is what the mountains and the woods should make you at last ashamed to assert.

George Santayana

King of the Mountain

Complete

Text not included in this edition.

Edward Cunningham (as circulated)

In the Woods Too

Excerpt

One-sentence excerpt from Nature, chapter 1.

In the woods too, a man casts off his years, as the snake his slough, and at what period soever of life is always a child.

Ralph Waldo Emerson

Mountains and Deserts

Complete

Complete circulating statement; original provenance unresolved.

Mountains and deserts, with their sparse life at the limit of existence, make one restless and disconsolate; one becomes an explorer in an intellectual realm as well as in a physical one.

George B. Schaller (as circulated)

He Who Reads the Landscape

Complete

Complete circulating statement; original provenance unresolved.

He who reads the landscape without the aid of maps as a matter of habit, becomes as sophisticated of eye as it is popular to believe the bat is sophisticated of ear.

Barry Lopez (as circulated)

When I Would Recreate Myself

Excerpt

Three sentences from "Walking."

When I would recreate myself, I seek the darkest wood, the thickest and most interminable and, to the citizen, most dismal, swamp. I enter a swamp as a sacred place--a sanctum sanctorum. There is the strength, the marrow, of Nature.

Henry David Thoreau

About Mountains; To the Attentive Eye

Composite; Excerpt

Composite of an unidentified mountain passage and one sentence from Emerson's Nature.

About mountains it is useless to argue, you have either been up or you haven't. The view from halfway is nobody's view. The best flowers are on top under a ledge, nourished by the wind. A sense of smell is of less importance than a sense of balance, walking on clouds through holes in which you can see the earth, the wind has its own level to find.

Author unknown

To the attentive eye, each moment of the year has its own beauty, and in the same field it beholds, every hour, a picture which was never seen before, and which shall never be seen again.

Anonymous and Ralph Waldo Emerson

He Who Has Achieved This State

Excerpt

Closing four lines of Tao Te Ching, chapter 56.

He who has achieved this state
Is unconcerned with friends and enemies,
With good and harm, with honor and disgrace.
This therefore is the highest state of man.

Laozi (traditional attribution)

Ability to See the Cultural Value of Wilderness

Abridged; Excerpt

Text not included in this edition.

Aldo Leopold

I Am in Love with This World

Abridged; Excerpt

Condensed passage from The Summit of the Years.

I am in love with this world; by my constitution I have nestled lovingly in it. . .
. I have climbed its mountains, roamed its forests, sailed its waters, crossed
its deserts, felt the sting of its frosts, the oppression of its heats, the drench of
its rains, the fury of its winds, and always have beauty and joy waited upon
my goings and comings.

John Burroughs

To Touch and Feel Is to Experience

Excerpt

Text not included in this edition.

Hyemeyohsts Storm

I Touched the Nothingness of Air

Excerpt

Text not included in this edition.

Nancy Wood (as printed; attribution unresolved)

Awareness Is Becoming Acquainted with Environment

Excerpt

Text not included in this edition.

Sigurd F. Olson

Simplicity in All Things

Excerpt

Text not included in this edition.

Sigurd F. Olson

How Often We Speak of the Great Silences

Excerpt

Text not included in this edition.

Sigurd F. Olson

On Friendship

Complete; Excerpt

Complete chapter from The Prophet.

And a youth said, Speak to us of Friendship.
And he answered, saying:

Your friend is your needs answered.
He is your field which you sow with love and reap with thanksgiving.
And he is your board and your fireside.
For you come to him with your hunger, and you seek him for peace.

When your friend speaks his mind you fear not the “nay” in your own mind,
nor do you withhold the “ay.”
And when he is silent your heart ceases not to listen to his heart;
For without words, in friendship, all thoughts, all desires, all expectations are
born and shared, with joy that is unacclaimed.
When you part from your friend, you grieve not;
For that which you love most in him may be clearer in his absence, as the
mountain to the climber is clearer from the plain.
And let there be no purpose in friendship save the deepening of the spirit.
For love that seeks aught but the disclosure of its own mystery is not love but a
net cast forth: and only the unprofitable is caught.

And let your best be for your friend.
If he must know the ebb of your tide, let him know its flood also.
For what is your friend that you should seek him with hours to kill?
Seek him always with hours to live.
For it is his to fill your need, but not your emptiness.
And in the sweetness of friendship let there be laughter, and sharing of pleasures.
For in the dew of little things the heart finds its morning and is refreshed.

Kahlil Gibran

Keep Your Mouth Closed

Excerpt

Middle seven lines of Tao Te Ching, chapter 56.

Keep your mouth closed.
Guard your senses.
Temper your sharpness.
Simplify your problems.
Mask your brightness.
Be at one with the dust of the earth.
This is primal union.

Laozi (traditional attribution)

A Farewell to Secretary Shu-yun

Excerpt

Closing four lines.

Since water still flows, though we cut it with swords,
And sorrows return, though we drown them with wine,
Since the world can in no way answer to our craving,
I will loosen my hair tomorrow and take to a fishing-boat.

Li Bai (Li Po)

Men Go Back to the Mountains

Complete

Text not included in this edition.

Abram T. Collier (as circulated)

A Land Ethic for Tomorrow

Excerpt

Text not included in this edition.

Stewart L. Udall

Difficulties and Obstructions

Excerpt

Text not included in this edition.

Richard Wilhelm and Cary F. Baynes

The Mountains Can Be Reached in All Seasons

Excerpt

Text not included in this edition.

William O. Douglas

The Concept of Public Welfare

Abridged; Excerpt

Excerpt from the Court's opinion in Berman v. Parker.

The concept of the public welfare is broad and inclusive. . . . The values it represents are spiritual as well as physical, aesthetic as well as monetary. It is within the power of the legislature to determine that the community should be beautiful as well as healthy, spacious as well as clean, well-balanced as well as carefully patrolled.

William O. Douglas, for a unanimous U.S. Supreme Court

The Art of Land Doctoring

Excerpt

Closing sentence of "Wilderness as a Land Laboratory."

The art of land doctoring is being practiced with vigor, but the science of land health is yet to be born.

Aldo Leopold

Winning Is Realizing You Already Have Won

Abridged; Composite; Excerpt

Text not included in this edition.

Joe Henderson

Man Always Kills the Thing He Loves

Abridged; Composite; Excerpt

Text not included in this edition.

Aldo Leopold

No Servant Brought Them Meals

Abridged; Excerpt

Text not included in this edition.

Aldo Leopold

Land, Then, Is Not Merely Soil

Excerpt

Text not included in this edition.

Aldo Leopold

The Universe Has Been Quite Literally Writing upon Humans

Excerpt

Closing lines of a longer reflection; booklet wording retained.

The universe has been quite literally writing upon humans for many thousands of years, and our alphabets are among the trails that nature has carved in order to cross our minds. Wild lands have cut deeper trails in my life than I will ever be able to make in the forest.

Joseph W. Meeker

While My Companion Contemplated

Abridged; Excerpt

Passage from Frankenstein, chapter 2.

While my companion contemplated with a serious and satisfied spirit the magnificent appearances of things, I delighted in investigating their causes. The world was to me a secret which I desired to divine. Curiosity, earnest research to learn the hidden laws of nature, gladness akin to rapture, as they were unfolded to me, are among the earliest sensations I can remember.

Mary Wollstonecraft Shelley

We of the Genus Homo Ride the Logs

Excerpt

Text not included in this edition.

Aldo Leopold

Our Newly Found Capacity

Complete

Text not included in this edition.

Arthur H. Carhart (as circulated)

The Death of a Tree

Excerpt

Text not included in this edition.

Edwin Way Teale

You Must Teach Your Children

Abridged; Adapted; Excerpt

Text not included in this edition.

Ted Perry, subsequently edited by John Stevens and anonymous adapters

Scouting and Adventures

Source-Corrected Edition

These Properties Are Donated and Dedicated

Complete

Complete Philmont dedication statement.

These properties are donated and dedicated to the Boy Scouts of America for the purpose of perpetuating faith, self-reliance, integrity, and freedom, principles used to build this great country by the American pioneer.

So that these future citizens may, through thoughtful adult guidance and by the inspiration of nature, visualize and form a code of living to diligently maintain these high ideals and our proper destiny.

Waite Phillips

It's Only a Pin

Complete

Complete poem.

A fond mother watches her boy where he stands,
Apart from his comrades tonight,
As they place on his camp-battered tunic, a badge...
An Eagle, the emblem of right.

It seems just a few short months have passed
Since he joined with the youngster next door.
How proud he was then of his Tenderfoot pin
As they told of the message it bore.

But the years have gone as he struggled along
To learn what the Scout Law's about;
He practiced them daily, the Oath and the Law,
Until now, he's an Eagle Scout.

You may smile in your worldly old wisdom at this
And say, "Why, it's only a pin."
But I tell you no honors he'll gain as a man
Will mean quite as much to him.

The red, white, and blue of the ribbon you see
Are the symbols of honor and truth.
He has learned how to value these fine attributes
In the glorious days of youth.

And the out-flinging wings of the Eagle that rests
On the breast of this knight of today
Are the things which will lift him above petty deeds,
And guide him along the right way.

Yes, it's only a pin, just an Eagle Scout badge,
But the heart that's beneath it beats true,
And will throb to the last for the things which are good;
A lesson for me... and for you.

S. Kurtz Hingley

One of the Best Paying Professions

Excerpt

Text not included in this edition.

Terry Russell and Renny Russell

I Am

Complete

Text not included in this edition.

James A. DeReign (as printed)

It's When You Are Safe at Home

Abridged; Adapted; Excerpt

Condensed paraphrase of Barnaby Tucker's closing speech in The Matchmaker.

It's when you are safe at home that you wish you were having an adventure.
When you're having an adventure you wish you were safe at home.

Thornton Wilder

I'd Rather Wake Up in the Middle of Nowhere

Complete

Complete reported statement.

I'd rather wake up in the middle of nowhere than in any city on earth.

Steve McQueen

Red Exhaustion Rips at Your Throat

Excerpt

Text not included in this edition.

Terry Russell and Renny Russell

Adventure Is Not in the Guidebook

Excerpt

Brief passage from On the Loose.

Adventure is not in the guidebook and Beauty is not on the map. Seek and ye shall find.

Terry Russell and Renny Russell

Walk Away Quietly

Abridged; Excerpt

Selected passage from "The Yellowstone National Park."

Walk away quietly in any direction and taste the freedom of the mountaineer.

...

Climb the mountains and get their good tidings. Nature's peace will flow into you as sunshine flows into trees. The winds will blow their own freshness into you, and the storms their energy, while cares will drop off like autumn leaves.

John Muir

The Mountains Are Calling

Excerpt

Opening clause from the closing sentence of Muir's September 3, 1873 letter.

The mountains are calling and I must go.

John Muir

To Travel Hopefully; For My Part, I Travel

Abridged; Composite; Excerpt

Composite of limited excerpts from "El Dorado" and Travels with a Donkey in the Cévennes.

To travel hopefully is a better thing than to arrive.

From "El Dorado"

For my part, I travel not to go anywhere, but to go.

From Travels with a Donkey in the Cévennes

Robert Louis Stevenson

Beauty

Source-Corrected Edition

I Looked Into The Face

Complete

Text not included in this edition.

Unknown

Pied Beauty

Complete

Complete poem.

Glory be to God for dappled things --
For skies of couple-colour as a brindled cow;
For rose-moles all in stipple upon trout that swim;
Fresh-firecoal chestnut-falls; finches' wings;
Landscape plotted and pieced -- fold, fallow, and plough;
And áll trádes, their gear and tackle and trim.

All things counter, original, spare, strange;
Whatever is fickle, freckled (who knows how?)
With swift, slow; sweet, sour; adazzle, dim;
He fathers-forth whose beauty is past change:
Praise him.

Gerard Manley Hopkins

Silently a Flower Blooms

Complete

Text not included in this edition.

Zenkei Shibayama

Beauty Is Composed of Many Things

Abridged; Excerpt

Text not included in this edition.

Sigurd F. Olson

Silent Noon

Complete

Complete sonnet.

Your hands lie open in the long fresh grass, --
The finger-points look through like rosy blooms:
Your eyes smile peace. The pasture gleams and glooms
'Neath billowing clouds that scatter and amass.
All round our nest, far as the eye can pass,
Are golden kingcup-fields with silver edge
Where the cow-parsley skirts the hawthorn-hedge.
'Tis visible silence, still as the hour-glass.

Deep in the sun-searched growths the dragon-fly
Hangs like a blue thread loosened from the sky: --
So this winged hour is dropt to us from above.
Oh! clasp we to our hearts, for deathless dower,
This close-companioned inarticulate hour
When twofold silence was the song of love.

Dante Gabriel Rossetti

The Sunshine on My Path

Excerpt

Two-line excerpt from "A Winter Piece."

The sunshine on my path
Was to me as a friend.

William Cullen Bryant

The Great Sea

Complete

Text not included in this edition.

UvavnuK

To the Virgins, to Make Much of Time

Excerpt

First stanza.

Gather ye rosebuds while ye may,
Old Time is still a-flying:
And this same flower that smiles to-day
To-morrow will be dying.

Robert Herrick

Nature Might Have Made the Sphinxes

Composite; Excerpt

Text not included in this edition.

Terry Russell and Renny Russell

Natural Beauty and Wonder

Complete

Brief complete quotation; originating work not located.

Natural beauty and wonder are priceless heirlooms which God has bestowed upon our nation. How shall we escape the contempt of the coming generation if we suffer this irreplaceable heritage to be wasted?

Henry van Dyke (attributed)

The Morning Hangs a Signal

Complete

Complete hymn, also known as "The Crowning Day."

The morning hangs a signal
Upon the mountain crest,
While all the sleeping valleys
In silent darkness rest.
From peak to peak it flashes,
It laughs along the sky,
Till glory of the sunlight
On all the land shall lie.

Above the generations
The lonely prophets rise,
While truth flares as the daystar

Within their glowing eyes.
And other eyes, beholding,
Are kindled from that light;
And dawn becomes the morning,
The darkness put to flight.

The soul hath lifted moments
Above the drift of days,
When life's great meaning breaketh
In sunrise on our ways.
Behold the radiant token
Of faith above all fear;
Night shall release its splendor,
And morning shall appear.

William Channing Gannett

God Had Infinite Time to Give Us

Abridged; Excerpt

Opening portion of a longer journal passage.

God had infinite time to give us; but how did He give it? In one immense tract of lazy millenniums? No, He cut it up into a neat succession of new mornings.

Ralph Waldo Emerson

Plants Should Be Regarded as Jewels

Fragment

Brief fragment of unresolved provenance.

[Plants should be regarded as] jewels in the devalued currency of our world environment.

Uberto Tosco (attribution unverified)

Who Walks with Beauty

Excerpt

Opening two lines of a fourteen-line sonnet.

Who walks with Beauty has no need of fear;
The sun and moon and stars keep pace with him.

David Morton

That Beautiful Season, the Summer

Abridged; Excerpt

Selected lines from Evangeline.

Then followed that beautiful season, the Summer! . . .
Filled was the air with a dreamy and magical light; and the landscape
Lay as if new-created in all the freshness of childhood.

Henry Wadsworth Longfellow

But Now the Sun Is Rising Calm and Bright

Adapted; Composite; Excerpt

Four noncontiguous clauses from the first two stanzas of "Resolution and Independence."

But now the sun is rising calm and bright. The birds are singing. . . . All things
that love the sun are out of doors. . . . The sky rejoices.

William Wordsworth

Nothing Gold Can Stay

Complete

Complete poem.

Nature's first green is gold.
Her hardest hue to hold.
Her early leaf's a flower;
But only so an hour.
Then leaf subsides to leaf.
So Eden sank to grief,
So dawn goes down to day.
Nothing gold can stay.

Robert Frost

With Beauty Before Me, May I Walk

Adapted; Excerpt

Text not included in this edition.

Traditional Diné prayer

Those Who Contemplate the Beauty of the Earth

Abridged; Composite; Excerpt

Text not included in this edition.

Rachel Carson

The Wonder of the World

Complete

Complete anonymous memorial inscription.

The wonder of the world, the beauty and the power, the shapes of things, their colours, lights and shades. These I saw. Look ye also while life lasts.

Unknown

Far Away There

Abridged; Excerpt

Shortened excerpt from Christie's speech in Work.

Far away there in the sunshine are my highest aspirations. I cannot reach them, but I can look up and see their beauty, believe in them, and try to follow where they lead.

Louisa May Alcott

Pine Tree Tops

Complete

Text not included in this edition.

Gary Snyder

Sometimes the Rare, the Beautiful

Excerpt

Text not included in this edition.

Loren Eiseley

No Synonym for God Is So Perfect as Beauty

Excerpt

No synonym for God is so perfect as Beauty.

Whether as seen carving the lines of the mountains with glaciers,
or gathering matter into stars, or planning the movements of water,
or gardening - still all is Beauty!

John Muir

Thank God They Cannot Cut Down the Clouds

Excerpt

Complete sentence quoted from Thoreau's journal.

Thank God they cannot cut down the clouds!

Henry David Thoreau

The Sun Does Not Shine for a Few Trees and Flowers

Excerpt

Opening sentence of a longer sermon passage.

The sun does not shine for a few trees and flowers, but for the wide world's joy.

Henry Ward Beecher

Nature Is Painting for Us

Complete

Brief aphorism; originating work not located.

Nature is painting for us, day after day, pictures of infinite beauty.

John Ruskin (attributed)

Riverbanks Lined with Green Trees

Complete

Brief saying of unresolved transmission.

Riverbanks lined with green trees, fragrant grasses: a place not sacred?
Where?

Traditional Zen saying (provenance unverified)

The Machine Turned Nature into an Art Form

Excerpt

Two consecutive sentences from Counterblast.

The machine turned Nature into an art form. For the first time men began to regard Nature as a source of aesthetic and spiritual values.

Marshall McLuhan

The Greatest Beauty Is Organic Wholeness

Abridged; Excerpt

Selected lines from "The Answer."

The greatest beauty is
Organic wholeness, the wholeness of life and things, the divine beauty
Of the universe. Love that, not man
Apart from that . . .

Robinson Jeffers

Looking Good Never Takes a Day Off

Complete

Brief saying of unresolved provenance.

Looking good never takes a day off.

Fr. Don Hummel (attribution unverified)

To Look at Any Thing

Complete

Text not included in this edition.

John Moffitt

Indifference to the Aesthetic

Abridged; Excerpt

Abbreviated sentence of unresolved provenance.

Indifference to the aesthetic will in the long run lessen the economic product.
... attention to the aesthetic will increase economic welfare.

Josiah Stamp (attribution unverified)

To See Is One of God's Great Gifts

Complete

Complete epigram with verified collection provenance.

To see is one of God's great gifts to man and to comprehend what we see is doubly so. Furthermore, He has endowed some people with the qualities to see the beauties of life and nature much more than others and they have the greatest gift of all.

Waite Phillips (collection attribution)

So Much for Me Here

Complete

Text not included in this edition.

Julie Fine (attribution unverified)

Our Ability to Perceive Quality in Nature

Excerpt

Text not included in this edition.

Aldo Leopold

Sequoias, Kings of Their Race

Excerpt

Mid-sentence excerpt from "The American Forests."

Sequoias, kings of their race, growing close together like grass in a meadow, poised their brave domes and spires in the sky, three hundred feet above the ferns and the lilies that enameled the ground; towering serene through the long centuries, preaching God's forestry fresh from heaven.

John Muir

I Remember

Complete

Text not included in this edition.

Unknown

We Believe That Ugliness Begets Ugliness

Excerpt

One-sentence excerpt from Carmer's Storm King testimony.

We believe that ugliness begets ugliness and that nature's beauty, once destroyed, may never be restored by the artifice of man.

Carl Carmer

Ordinarily the Demands of Utility Are Imperative

Excerpt

One-sentence excerpt from "Sentiment versus Utility in the Treatment of National Scenery."

Ordinarily the demands of utility are imperative and scenic beauty where it stands in the way must yield.

Hiram Martin Chittenden

There Can Be No Greater Moral Obligation

Excerpt

Closing-page sentence from the final lecture in Wilderness and Plenty.

There can be no greater moral obligation than to ease out the living space and replace dereliction by beauty.

Frank Fraser Darling

For Oft When on My Couch I Lie

Excerpt

Final stanza of "I Wandered Lonely as a Cloud."

For oft when on my couch I lie
In vacant or in pensive mood,
They flash upon that inward eye
Which is the bliss of solitude,
And then my heart with pleasure fills,
And dances with the Daffodils.

William Wordsworth

Oh, These Vast, Calm, Measureless Mountain Days

Excerpt

First two sentences of Muir's June 23, 1869 journal entry.

Oh, these vast, calm, measureless mountain days, inciting at once to work and rest! Days in whose light everything seems equally divine, opening a thousand windows to show us God.

John Muir

Thus It Appears That Everything Here Is Marching to Music

Abridged; Excerpt

Opening portion of a longer notebook sentence.

Thus it appears that everything here is marching to music & the harmonies are all so simple & young they are easily apprehended by those who will keep still & listen & look. . . .

John Muir

Everybody Needs Beauty as Well as Bread

Excerpt

One-sentence excerpt from "Hetch Hetchy Valley."

Everybody needs beauty as well as bread, places to play in and pray in, where Nature may heal and cheer and give strength to body and soul alike.

John Muir

The Mountains Are Fountains of Men

Excerpt

Two consecutive journal sentences.

The mountains are fountains of men as well as of rivers, of glaciers, of fertile soil. The great poets, philosophers, prophets, able men whose thoughts and deeds have moved the world, have come down from the mountains -- mountain-dwellers who have grown strong there with the forest trees in Nature's workshops.

John Muir

How Deep Our Sleep Last Night in the Mountain's Heart

Complete

Complete journal entry for June 9, 1869.

How deep our sleep last night in the mountain's heart, beneath the trees and stars, hushed by solemn-sounding waterfalls and many small soothing voices in sweet accord whispering peace! And our first pure mountain day, warm, calm, cloudless, -- how immeasurable it seems, how serenely wild! I can scarcely remember its beginning. Along the river, over the hills, in the ground, in the sky, spring work is going on with joyful enthusiasm, new life, new beauty, unfolding, unrolling in glorious exuberant extravagance, -- new birds in their nests, new winged creatures in the air, and new leaves, new flowers, spreading, shining, rejoicing everywhere.

John Muir

Here Is Calm

Abridged; Excerpt

Opening portion of a longer prose note.

Here is calm so deep, grasses cease waving. . . . Wonderful how completely everything in wild nature fits into us, as if truly part and parent of us. The sun shines not on us but in us. The rivers flow not past, but through us, thrilling, tingling, vibrating every fiber and cell of the substance of our bodies, making them glide and sing.

John Muir

I Care to Live Only to Entice People

Adapted; Composite; Excerpt

Composite of language adapted from two letters to Jeanne C. Carr.

I care to live only to entice people to look at Nature's loveliness. My own special self is nothing.

From the letter of October 7, 1874

I want to be like a flake of glass through which light passes.

Adapted from the letter of December 25, 1872

John Muir

These Beautiful Days Must Enrich All My Life

Abridged; Excerpt

Shortened journal passage.

These beautiful days must enrich all my life. They do not exist as mere pictures -- maps hung upon the walls of memory . . . but they saturate themselves into every part of the body and live always.

John Muir

Then Casting Up My Eyes

Adapted; Excerpt

Sentence ending from Abel's narration in Green Mansions.

Then casting up my eyes, [I] thanked the Author of my being for the gift of that wild forest, those green mansions where I had found so great a happiness!

William Henry Hudson

Beauty Created by Nature Is Equal in Value To

Complete

Text not included in this edition.

David Sive (attribution unverified)

The Heavens Declare God's Glory

Adapted; Excerpt

Text not included in this edition.

Psalms 19:1-6 (paraphrase; translator unidentified)

Nothing Is Less Known; Nothing More Neglected

Excerpt

Two consecutive sentences in English translation.

Nothing is less known; nothing more neglected. The forest is a gift of nature which it is sufficient to accept just as it comes from her hands.

Georges-Louis Leclerc, Comte de Buffon

The Thoughts of the Earth Are My Thoughts

Abridged; Adapted; Excerpt

Text not included in this edition.

Diné song tradition (source and translator unverified)

If There Is Light in the Soul

Complete

Text not included in this edition.

Commonly labeled Chinese proverb (provenance unverified)

The Hours When the Mind Is Absorbed by Beauty

Excerpt

One-sentence excerpt from "The Pageant of Summer."

The hours when the mind is absorbed by beauty are the only hours when we really live.

Richard Jefferies

Then I Was Standing on the Highest Mountain

Excerpt

Text not included in this edition.

Nicholas Black Elk, as told through John G. Neihardt

Wilderness

Source-Corrected Edition

If These Mountains Die

Abridged; Excerpt

Text not included in this edition.

John Treadwell Nichols

A Profound, a Fundamental Need for Areas of Wilderness

Abridged; Adapted; Composite; Excerpt

Two selected clauses from consecutive portions of "The Need for Wilderness Areas."

We have a profound, a fundamental need for areas of wilderness. . . . This need is for areas of the earth within which we stand without our mechanisms that make us immediate masters over our environment.

Howard Zahniser

So Rests the Sky Against the Earth

Complete

Text not included in this edition.

Dag Hammarskjöld

There Is a Limit to the Number of Lands of Shoreline

Abridged; Excerpt

Selected passage from Carhart's December 1919 memorandum.

There is a limit to the number of lands of shoreline on the lakes; there is a limit to the number of lakes in existence; there is a limit to the mountainous areas of the world, and . . . there are portions of natural scenic beauty which are God-made and . . . which of a right should be the property of all people.

Arthur Hawthorne Carhart

The Land Belongs to the Future

Abridged; Excerpt

Most of Alexandra Bergson's closing speech to Carl Linstrum, beginning after its opening sentence.

The land belongs to the future, Carl; that's the way it seems to me. How many of the names on the county clerk's plat will be there in fifty years? I might as well try to will the sunset over there to my brother's children. We come and go, but the land is always here. And the people who love it and understand it are the people who own it—for a little while.

Willa Cather

Beatus Vir

Abridged; Composite; Excerpt

First and fourth stanzas of the four-stanza poem.

Happy is the man who loves the woods and waters,
Brother to the grass, and well-beloved of Pan;
The earth shall be his, and all her laughing daughters—
Happy the man.

[Two stanzas omitted.]

His gossips are the stars, and the moon-rise his tavern;
He who seeks a better find it if he can—
And O his sweet pillow in the ferny cavern!
Happy the man.

Richard Le Gallienne

Touch the Earth, Love the Earth

Excerpt

*Two clauses from the closing passage of *The Outermost House*.*

Touch the earth, love the earth, honor the earth, her plains, her valleys, her hills, and her seas; rest your spirit in her solitary places.

Henry Beston

Today the Open Road Is a Six Lane Highway

Excerpt

Text not included in this edition.

Eve Merriam (attribution not independently sourced)

I Have Been Told with Some Regularity

Excerpt

Text not included in this edition.

Colin Fletcher

A Mountain Brook

Complete

Text not included in this edition.

Ch'u Kuang-hsi (Chu Guangxi); translated by Kenneth Rexroth

The Control of Nature

Excerpt

Opening sentence of the concluding argument in "The Other Road."

The control of nature is a phrase conceived in arrogance, born of the Neanderthal age of biology and philosophy, when it was supposed that nature exists for the convenience of man.

Rachel Carson

That Wonderful World of High Mountains

Excerpt

Three sentences from the English translation of Devies's preface to Annapurna.

That wonderful world of high mountains, dazzling in their rock and ice, acts as a catalyst. It suggests the infinite but it is not the infinite. The heights only give us what we ourselves bring them.

Lucien Devies; translated by Nea Morin and Janet Adam Smith

When Night Is Almost Done

Complete

When Night is almost done—
And Sunrise grows so near
That we can touch the Spaces—
It's time to smooth the Hair—
And get the Dimples ready—
And wonder we could care
For that old—faded Midnight—
That frightened—but an Hour—

Emily Dickinson

Earth Laughs in Flowers

Fragment; Excerpt

Opening clause of a line in "Hamatreya."

Earth laughs in flowers.

Ralph Waldo Emerson

I Do Not Know of a Flowering Plant

Complete

I do not know of a flowering plant that tastes good and is poisonous. Nature is not out to get you.

Euell Gibbons (attribution not independently sourced)

Since the Land Is the Parent

Adapted; Excerpt

Loose modernization of Republic 3.414e.

Since the land is the parent, let the citizens take care of her more carefully than children do their mother.

Plato; translator or paraphraser unidentified

Let Us Dance in the Sun

Complete

Text not included in this edition.

Susan Polis Schutz (attribution not independently sourced)

Nature Is More Than a Refuge

Excerpt

Opening two sentences of The Road of a Naturalist.

Nature is more than a refuge from human chaos, more than fresh air for smoke-filled lungs, and quietude from ears in torture. It is the common way of living, and as such it is our touchstone.

Donald Culross Peattie

There Is No Graduation from the School of the Outdoors

Complete

There is no graduation from the school of the outdoors.

Unknown

[The Clearest Way into the Universe] / Deep in the Mountain Wilderness

Complete; Composite; Excerpt

Muir journal sentence followed in the booklet by Kenneth Rexroth's complete translation of Wang Wei.

The clearest way into the Universe is through a forest wilderness.

John Muir

Additional text not included in this edition.

John Muir; Wang Wei, translated by Kenneth Rexroth

We Must Not Only Protect the Countryside

Abridged; Composite; Excerpt

One sentence from Johnson's 1965 conservation message, followed by two sentences selected from his 1964 Great Society address.

We must not only protect the countryside and save it from destruction, we must restore what has been destroyed and salvage the beauty and charm of our cities.

[Text from the two different addresses is not continuous.]

Once our natural splendor is destroyed, it can never be recaptured. And once man can no longer walk with beauty or wonder at nature his spirit will wither and his sustenance be wasted.

Lyndon Baines Johnson

A New "Pledge of Allegiance"

Complete

Text not included in this edition.

Bruce Hagen (attribution not independently sourced)

Nature Includes All of the Universe

Complete

Nature includes all of the universe and man is not only a part of nature, he is in it up to his neck.

Norman John Berrill (attribution not independently sourced)

The Landscapes Were Like a Violin Bow

Excerpt

English rendering of a sentence from Vie de Henry Brulard.

The landscapes were like a violin bow that played upon my soul.

Stendhal (Marie-Henri Beyle); English translator unidentified

There Is Not as Much Wilderness Out There

Complete

There is not as much wilderness out there as I wish there were. There is more inside than you think.

David Ross Brower (attribution not independently sourced)

All Living Creatures and All Plants

Excerpt

One sentence from a longer transmitted statement.

All living creatures and all plants are a benefit to something.

Shooter (also recorded as Okute), Teton Sioux; recorder and translator unidentified

The Earth, Like the Sun, Like the Air

Excerpt

Closing sentence of "Come On In."

The earth, like the sun, like the air, belongs to everyone—and to no one.

Edward Paul Abbey

Wilderness Is Nature's Bank

Complete

Wilderness is nature's bank of genetic variability.

Aldo Leopold (attribution not independently sourced)

The Idea of Wilderness Needs No Defense

Adapted; Excerpt

Two sentences from "Shadows from the Big Woods."

The idea of wilderness needs no defense. It only needs more defenders.

Edward Paul Abbey

A Thing Is Right When It Tends to Preserve

Excerpt

Two consecutive sentences from "The Land Ethic."

A thing is right when it tends to preserve the integrity, stability, and beauty of the biotic community. It is wrong when it tends otherwise.

Aldo Leopold

Sangre de Cristo Mountains

Complete

Text not included in this edition.

Phillips Kloss (attribution not independently sourced)

Money Is the Wealth of the Materialists

Complete

Money is the wealth of the materialists and works miracles in the realm of the physical. Time is the wealth of the pilgrim, and works miracles in all realms.

Ed Buryn

The Negro Speaks of Rivers

Complete

I've known rivers:

I've known rivers ancient as the world and older than the
flow of human blood in human veins.

My soul has grown deep like the rivers.

I bathed in the Euphrates when dawns were young.
I built my hut near the Congo and it lulled me to sleep.
I looked upon the Nile and raised the pyramids above it.
I heard the singing of the Mississippi when Abe Lincoln
went down to New Orleans, and I've seen its muddy
bosom turn all golden in the sunset.

I've known rivers:

Ancient, dusky rivers.

My soul has grown deep like the rivers.

Langston Hughes

Nature Shows Us Only Surfaces

Excerpt

Second sentence of a two-sentence observation in "Resources."

Nature shows us only surfaces, but she is million fathoms deep.

Ralph Waldo Emerson

And Forget Not That the Earth Delights

Complete

And forget not that the earth delights to feel your bare feet and the winds long to play with your hair.

Kahlil Gibran

We Are the Most Dangerous Species

Excerpt

Text not included in this edition.

Wallace Earle Stegner

The Still Mind of the Sage

Fragment; Excerpt

First clause of a sentence in "The Way of Heaven."

The still mind of the sage is the mirror of heaven and earth.

Zhuang Zhou; translated by James Legge

Once in a While You Find a Place on Earth

Complete

Text not included in this edition.

Unknown; "Sundance" may identify a publication or commercial source

Gueorgui Loved the Forest

Complete

Gueorgui loved the forest, this forest as old as a legend, gentle as a mother, and stern as a father.

Nikolai Levkov (identity and transliteration provisional); translator unidentified

Your Equipment Stands Between You and the Wilderness

Excerpt

Text not included in this edition.

Ed Buryn

The Supreme Reality of Our Time

Adapted; Excerpt

One sentence from Kennedy's address to the Irish Parliament.

The supreme reality of our time is our indivisibility as children of God and our common vulnerability on this planet.

John Fitzgerald Kennedy

Humanity Is Cutting Down Forests

Complete

Humanity is cutting down forests, apparently oblivious to the fact that we may not be able to live without them.

Isaac Asimov (attribution not independently sourced)

Remember Thy Creator in the Days of Thy Youth

Adapted; Composite; Excerpt

Ecclesiastes 12:1 followed by selected sentences from "The Ponds," arranged in On the Loose.

Remember thy Creator in the days of thy youth.

Rise free from care before the dawn, and seek adventures. Let noon find thee by other lakes, and the night overtake thee everywhere at home. There are no larger fields than these, no worthier games than may here be played.

Ecclesiastes 12:1; Henry David Thoreau; arranged by Terry Russell and Renny Russell

I Look Forward to an America

Excerpt

One sentence from Kennedy's closing vision at Amherst College.

I look forward to an America which will not be afraid of grace and beauty, which will protect the beauty of our natural environment, which will preserve the great old American houses and squares and parks of our national past, and which will build handsome and balanced cities for our future.

John Fitzgerald Kennedy

When I Got to Be 70

Abridged; Excerpt

Text not included in this edition.

Claudia Alta "Lady Bird" Johnson

Man Is Not Himself Only

Abridged; Excerpt

Text not included in this edition.

Mary Hunter Austin

Waka on the Diamond Sutra

Complete

Text not included in this edition.

Eihei Dōgen; translated by Lucien Stryk and Takashi Ikemoto

At First, the People Talking About Ecology

Complete

Text not included in this edition.

Osmarino Amâncio Rodrigues

Her Mighty Lakes, Like Oceans of Liquid Silver

Excerpt

Extended sentence from "The Author's Account of Himself."

Her mighty lakes, like oceans of liquid silver; her mountains, with their bright aerial tints; her valleys, teeming with wild fertility; her tremendous cataracts, thundering in their solitudes; her boundless plains, waving with spontaneous verdure; her broad deep rivers, rolling in solemn silence to the ocean; her trackless forests, where vegetation puts forth all its magnificence; her skies, kindling with the magic of summer clouds and glorious sunshine; no, never need an American look beyond his own country for the sublime and beautiful of natural scenery.

Washington Irving

Home to the Wilderness

Excerpt

Text not included in this edition.

Sally Carrighar

Song of the Open Road

Complete

Text not included in this edition.

Ogden Nash

The Earth, Born in Fire

Complete

Text not included in this edition.

E. V. Komarek Sr. (attribution provisional)

I Am Part of My Environment

Complete

Text not included in this edition.

Unknown

The Good News Is That Americans Will

Excerpt

Closing observation attributed to "The Land Between."

The good news is that Americans will, in increasing numbers, begin to value and protect the vast American landscape. The bad news is that they may love it to death.

Charles E. Little

Come, Little Leaves

Adapted; Excerpt

First stanza.

"Come, little leaves," said the wind one day,
"Come o'er the meadows with me and play;
Put on your dresses of red and gold,
For summer is gone and the days grow cold."

George Cooper

Laws Change; People Die

Adapted

Modern paraphrase of an argument in Lincoln's Second Annual Message.

Laws change; people die; the land remains.

Unknown paraphraser after Abraham Lincoln

The Birds I Heard Today

Excerpt

Journal sentence collected in Early Spring in Massachusetts.

The birds I heard today, which, fortunately, did not come within the scope of my science, sang as freshly as if it had been the first morning of creation.

Henry David Thoreau

Stopping by Woods on a Snowy Evening

Complete

Whose woods these are I think I know.
His house is in the village though;
He will not see me stopping here
To watch his woods fill up with snow.

My little horse must think it queer
To stop without a farmhouse near
Between the woods and the frozen lake
The darkest evening of the year.

He gives his harness bells a shake
To ask if there is some mistake.
The only other sound's the sweep
Of easy wind and downy flake.

The woods are lovely, dark and deep,
But I have promises to keep,
And miles to go before I sleep,
And miles to go before I sleep.

Robert Frost

This Grand Show Is Eternal

Excerpt

Posthumously published journal passage.

This grand show is eternal. It is always sunrise somewhere; the dew is never all dried at once; a shower is forever falling; vapor ever rising. Eternal sunrise, eternal sunset, eternal dawn and gloaming, on seas and continents and islands, each in its turn, as the round earth rolls.

John Muir

This Is the Forest Primeval

Abridged; Fragment; Excerpt

Fragments from the opening lines of the Prelude to Evangeline.

This is the forest primeval. The murmuring pines and the hemlocks,

[Two lines omitted.]

Stand like Druids of eld.

Henry Wadsworth Longfellow

The Essence of What We Call America

Complete

(The essence of what) we call America lies not so much in political institutions as in its rocks and skies and seas.

Paul Strand (attribution not independently sourced)

We Love the Quiet

Complete

We love the quiet, we suffer the mouse to play; when the woods are rustled by the wind, we fear not.

Unidentified Indigenous speaker

Conservation Is the Foresighted Utilization

Excerpt

Conservation is the foresighted utilization, preservation, and/or renewal of forests, waters, lands and minerals for the greatest good of the greatest number for the longest time.

Gifford Pinchot

Holy Mother Earth

Complete

Holy Mother Earth, the trees and all nature, are witnesses of your thoughts and deeds.

Anonymous; Ho-Chunk/Winnebago attribution unverified

Isaiah 5:8

Complete

Woe unto them that join house to house, that lay field to field, till there be no place, that they may be placed alone in the midst of the earth!

Book of Isaiah

The Pasture

Complete

I'm going out to clean the pasture spring;
I'll only stop to rake the leaves away
(And wait to watch the water clear, I may):
I sha'n't be gone long.—You come too.

I'm going out to fetch the little calf
That's standing by the mother. It's so young,
It totters when she licks it with her tongue.
I sha'n't be gone long.—You come too.

Robert Frost

Science Has Never Drummed Up

Complete

Science has never drummed up quite as effective a tranquilizing agent as a sunny spring day.

W. Earl Hall (attribution not independently sourced)

My Heart Is Tuned to the Quietness

Complete

My heart is tuned to the quietness that the stillness of nature inspires.

Hazrat Inayat Khan

What a Joy It Is to Feel the Soft, Springy Earth

Excerpt

Autobiographical sentence from The Story of My Life.

What a joy it is to feel the soft, springy earth under my feet once more, to follow grassy roads that lead to ferny brooks where I can bathe my fingers in a cataract of rippling notes, or to clamber over a stone wall into green fields that tumble and roll and climb in riotous gladness!

Helen Keller

The Care of Rivers

Complete

The care of rivers is not a question of rivers, but of the human heart.

Tanaka Shōzō (attribution provisional); translator unidentified

No Pain Here

Composite; Excerpt

Two Muir journal sentiments transmitted together.

No pain here, no dull empty hours, no fear of the past, no fear of the Future.

[Exact continuity between the two statements has not been established.]

Drinking this champagne water is pure pleasure, so is breathing the living air.

John Muir

I Am Always Glad to Touch the Living Rock

Abridged; Excerpt

I . . . am always glad to touch the living rock again and dip my hand in the high mountain air.

John Muir

Thousands of Tired, Nerve-Shaken, Over-Civilized People

Excerpt

Sentence from the opening chapter of Our National Parks.

Thousands of tired, nerve-shaken, over-civilized people are beginning to find out that going to the mountains is going home; that wildness is a necessity; and that mountain parks and reservations are useful not only as fountains of timber and irrigating rivers, but as fountains of life.

John Muir

And This, Our Life Exempt from Public Haunt

Excerpt

Duke Senior, in As You Like It.

And this our life, exempt from public haunt,
Finds tongues in trees, books in the running brooks,
Sermons in stones, and good in everything.

William Shakespeare

Nature and Democracy—Morality

Adapted; Excerpt

Sentence from Whitman's prose meditation.

American Democracy, in its myriad personalities, in factories, work-shops, stores, offices—through the dense streets and houses of cities, and all their manifold sophisticated life—must either be fibred, vitalized, by regular contact with out-door light and air and growths, farm-scenes, animals, fields, trees, birds, sun-warmth and free skies, or it will certainly dwindle and pale.

Walt Whitman

Sand Dunes

Complete

Sea waves are green and wet,
But up from where they die
Rise others vaster yet,
And those are brown and dry.
They are the sea made land
To come at the fisher town
And bury in solid sand
The men she could not drown.
She may know cove and cape,
But she does not know mankind
If by any change of shape
She hopes to cut off mind.
Men left her a ship to sink:
They can leave her a hut as well:
And be but more free to think
For the one more cast off shell.

Robert Frost

There Is Just One Hope of Repulsing

Excerpt

Closing call to action from "The Problem of the Wilderness."

There is just one hope of repulsing the tyrannical ambition of civilization to conquer every niche on the whole earth. That hope is the organization of spirited people who will fight for the freedom of the wilderness.

Robert Marshall

A Thousand Fantasies Begin to Throng

Abridged; Composite; Excerpt

The opening two and closing lines of a five-line passage from Comus.

A thousand fantasies
Begin to throng into my memory,

[Two lines omitted.]

On sands and shores and desert wildernesses.

John Milton

Miller Owns This Field

Abridged; Excerpt

Most of the landscape paragraph from chapter 1 of Nature, beginning after its first sentence.

Miller owns this field, Locke that, and Manning the woodland beyond. But none of them owns the landscape. There is a property in the horizon which no man has but he whose eye can integrate all the parts, that is, the poet. This is the best part of these men's farms, yet to this their warranty-deeds give no title.

Ralph Waldo Emerson

One Touch of Nature

Excerpt

One line from Ulysses's speech in Troilus and Cressida.

One touch of nature makes the whole world kin,

William Shakespeare

On the Natural

Adapted; Fragment; Excerpt

Text not included in this edition.

Hoyt Axton

Into My Own

Complete

One of my wishes is that those dark trees,
So old and firm they scarcely show the breeze,
Were not, as 'twere, the merest mask of gloom,
But stretched away unto the edge of doom.
I should not be withheld but that some day
Into their vastness I should steal away,
Fearless of ever finding open land,
Or highway where the slow wheel pours the sand.
I do not see why I should e'er turn back,
Or those should not set forth upon my track
To overtake me, who should miss me here
And long to know if still I held them dear.
They would not find me changed from him they knew—
Only more sure of all I thought was true.

Robert Frost

It Was Kind of Solemn

Abridged; Excerpt

Shortened sentence from chapter 12 of Adventures of Huckleberry Finn.

It was kind of solemn, drifting down the big, still river, laying on our backs looking up at the stars, and we didn't ever feel like talking loud.

Mark Twain (Samuel L. Clemens)

I Conceive That the Land Belongs

Complete

Reported testimony concerning customary Yoruba land tenure.

I conceive that the land belongs to a vast family of which many are dead, few are living, and countless numbers are still unborn.

Unidentified Yoruba chief (reported testimony)

This Is About a Stretch of Mountain Country

Abridged; Excerpt

Text not included in this edition.

David L. Caffey

To Us the Ashes of Our Ancestors Are Sacred

Excerpt

Sentence from Henry A. Smith's disputed 1887 reconstruction.

To us the ashes of our ancestors are sacred and their resting place is hallowed ground.

Henry A. Smith (1887 reconstruction attributed to Chief Seattle)

There Is No Quiet Place in the White Man's Cities

Excerpt

Two sentences from Perry's screenplay for Home.

There is no quiet place in the white man's cities. No place to hear the unfurling of leaves in spring, or the rustle of an insect's wings.

Ted Perry

The Land, the Earth God Gave to Man

Abridged; Excerpt

Shortened circulating statement, first documented long after Lincoln's death.

The land, the earth God gave to man for his home... should never be the possession of any man, corporation, [or] society... any more than the air or water.

Unknown; attributed to Abraham Lincoln without contemporary evidence

Sleeping in the Forest

Complete

Text not included in this edition.

Mary Oliver

There Is No Plant That Is Unimportant

Excerpt

Two-sentence conservation statement from a 1978 Smithsonian interview.

There is no plant that is unimportant. The genetic information contained in the germ plasm of each species is unique and cannot be reproduced once the last living tissue is gone.

Edward S. Ayensu

We Are No Longer Nature's Children

Complete

We are no longer nature's children; we are her masters.

Richard Garfield (attribution provisional)

Land Is Immortal

Complete

Land is immortal, for it harbors the mysteries of creation.

Anwar el-Sadat (attribution provisional)

General Prologue to The Canterbury Tales

Excerpt

Lines 11-14 in an unidentified modern translation.

For in their hearts doth Nature stir them so,
Then people long on pilgrimage to go,
And palmers to be seeking foreign strands,
To distant shrines renowned in sundry lands.

Geoffrey Chaucer; modern translator unidentified

Parks Are at the Center of a Community's Character

Complete

Parks are at the center of a community's character; they reflect and strengthen the sense of place and identity that makes cities fit places for people.

The Conservation Foundation

The Call of the Wild

Complete

Have you gazed on naked grandeur where there's nothing else to gaze on,
Set pieces and drop-curtain scenes galore,
Big mountains heaved to heaven, which the blinding sunsets blazon,
Black canyons where the rapids rip and roar?
Have you swept the visioned valley with the green stream streaking through it,
Searched the Vastness for a something you have lost?
Have you strung your soul to silence? Then for God's sake go and do it;
Hear the challenge, learn the lesson, pay the cost.

Have you wandered in the wilderness, the sagebrush desolation,
The bunch-grass levels where the cattle graze?
Have you whistled bits of rag-time at the end of all creation,
And learned to know the desert's little ways?
Have you camped upon the foothills, have you galloped o'er the ranges,
Have you roamed the arid sun-lands through and through?
Have you chummed up with the mesa? Do you know its moods and changes?
Then listen to the Wild—it's calling you.

Have you known the Great White Silence, not a snow-gemmed twig aquiver?
(Eternal truths that shame our soothing lies.)
Have you broken trail on snowshoes? mushed your huskies up the river,
Dared the unknown, led the way, and clutched the prize?
Have you marked the map's void spaces, mingled with the mongrel races,
Felt the savage strength of brute in every thew?
And though grim as hell the worst is, can you round it off with curses?
Then hearken to the Wild—it's wanting you.

Have you suffered, starved and triumphed, groveled down, yet grasped at
glory,
Grown bigger in the bigness of the whole?
"Done things" just for the doing, letting babblers tell the story,
Seeing through the nice veneer the naked soul?
Have you seen God in His splendors, heard the text that nature renders?
(You'll never hear it in the family pew.)
The simple things, the true things, the silent men who do things—
Then listen to the Wild—it's calling you.

They have cradled you in custom, they have primed you with their preaching,
They have soaked you in convention through and through;
They have put you in a showcase; you're a credit to their teaching—
But can't you hear the Wild?—it's calling you.
Let us probe the silent places, let us seek what luck betide us;
Let us journey to a lonely land I know.

There's a whisper on the night-wind, there's a star agleam to guide us,
And the Wild is calling, calling... let us go.

Robert W. Service

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About This Edition

Wilderness Reflections began as a Philmont staff collection in 1985 and grew through several historical editions. This First Field Edition was prepared from a page-verified transcription of the surviving booklet and a selection-by-selection source review.

The repository preserves the scan-faithful transcription, source evidence, unresolved attribution questions, and the canonical source-corrected Markdown used for this publication. Eighty-three identified selections are represented without their source text because permission or a sufficiently reliable reproducible witness was unavailable.

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